to the ambassador of China on 23 October in New Delhi, ‘another party under the direction of a senior officer, went out to continue the search. This party was surprised by sudden fire from a Chinese armed force entrenched on a hilltop, which used automatic weapons and hand grenades. Apparently, the Indian personnel fired back in self-defence, but were overwhelmed by the strategic situation and the superior strength and firepower of the Chinese troops. According to the latest report, as many as seventeen persons belonging to the Indian party, including the officer-in-charge, have lost their lives and some others have suffered severe injuries.’ India also alleged that the Chinese had used mortars for the first time in any border engagement, a fact that was denied by the Chinese.

Through a diplomatic note, the Chinese had subsequently informed the Indian ambassador in Peking that their ‘frontier guards’ were prepared to turn over the bodies of nine soldiers (just as New Delhi insisted they were border police, the Chinese always referred to them as soldiers) and return ten prisoners. Accordingly, the Indians were handed over on 14 November near Kongka Pass along with their arms and ammunition. The party had by then been in Chinese captivity for more than twenty days and the Indians were extremely suspicious that the prisoners had been subjected to Maoist ‘brainwashing’ techniques.

At the prisoner return ceremony, the leader of the group, Karam Singh, waved goodbye to his Chinese captors, immediately setting off alarm bells on the Indian side. Around the same time, Chou En-lai, in an interview given to the editor of a leftist publication of the India-USSR Society for Cultural Relations, claimed that Karam Singh had ‘confessed’ that the Chinese had not used mortars in the clash on 21 October as India had alleged. When this information became public, a wave of anger swept through Parliament and the Indian media.

The issue assumed great importance over the next few days. In the aftermath of the Kongka Pass incident, while India awaited a reply from the Chinese, it had been declared on 1 November that henceforth the Indian Army would take over the border from the border police in the Western Sector as well. Three days after the POWs and the bodies were returned, the Indians issued a formal protest note, stating that while in Chinese custody, the Indians were ‘kept under severe living conditions’ and subjected to constant interrogation, pressure and threats in an attempt to force them ‘to make statements desired by their captors’.